Unlocking the mysteries of the Great Lakes: Contribute to snail research

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Participate in our mystery snail collection project and become a guardian of the Great Lakes.



A mystery snail. Photo: Oregon Department of Fish & Wildlife, CC BY-SA 2.0, via Wikimedia Commons

Are you passionate about the Great Lakes and eager to support scientific research aimed at preserving these bodies of water? We have just the opportunity for you! Our newly-designed webpage is your portal to aiding crucial research on mystery snails in the Great Lakes region.

Dive Into participatory science

At the Great Lakes Aquatic Nonindigenous Species Information System (GLANSIS,) we believe groundbreaking research thrives on community involvement. Our latest initiative calls on participatory scientists to help collect, document, and ship the mystery snails *Cipangopaludina chinensis* and *Cipangopaludina japonica* to support worldwide research being done by scientists with George Mason University. These non-native species could have ecological impacts on the Great Lakes. This is your chance to contribute to meaningful environmental science, while exploring the beauty of these waters.

Why your participation matters

The introduction of mystery snails into the Great Lakes has raised concerns among ecological researchers. These snails can alter food webs, compete with native species, and introduce parasites. Understanding their distribution, abundance, and impact is vital for developing strategies to protect our lakes. Researchers at George Mason University will use the latest genetic techniques to identify which species each mystery snail is and identify any parasites it hosts. Your active participation helps us gather the data needed to monitor and manage this species effectively.

How it works

Getting involved is easy and rewarding:

- **Visit the website**: Navigate to our Contribute Mystery Snails landing page.
- **Learn and equip**: Familiarize yourself with the characteristics of mystery snails through our species profiles.
- **Go exploring**: Head to your local lake or stream and start hunting for mystery snails. Check out our location map to see where populations have been documented and where samples are needed.
- **Collect and document**: Carefully collect the snails, take photos, and note down important details such as location, date, and environmental conditions. Aim to collect a minimum of 30 adult snails from each independent water body.
- **Submit your specimens**: Ship your snails following the instructions listed in the 'Shipping' section of our webpage. Each submission brings us closer to unraveling the mystery of these invasive snails.

Benefits of participating

- **Hands-on learning**: Gain practical experience in fieldwork and contribute to a better understanding of invasive species.
- **Community contribution**: Join a network of concerned citizens and scientists working together towards a common goal.
- **Impactful involvement**: Your efforts directly aid in preserving the ecological health of the Great Lakes, a vital resource for millions of people.

Join the movement

Participatory science is more than just a hobby — it's a powerful tool for environmental stewardship. By participating in our mystery snail collection project, you become a guardian of the Great Lakes. We invite you to explore our species profiles, dive into the fascinating world of snails, and make a tangible difference in protecting our precious water resources.

Whether you're a seasoned biologist, a curious student, or simply a nature enthusiast, your contribution is invaluable. Let's unite our efforts and ensure the Great Lakes remain vibrant and thriving for generations to come.

Visit our Contribute Mystery Snails Landing Page and start your journey in participatory science. For any inquiries or additional information, please contact GLANSIS at oar.glerl.glansis@noaa.gov or follow us on X. Together, we can unlock the secrets of the Great Lakes.

Michigan Sea Grant helps to foster economic growth and protect Michigan's coastal, Great Lakes resources through education, research and outreach. A collaborative effort of the University of Michigan and Michigan State University and its MSU Extension, Michigan Sea Grant is part of the NOAA-National Sea Grant network of 34 university-based programs.

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